Nehru's handling of foreign affairs on a daily basis is described in detail by former foreign secretary, Yezdezard Dinshaw Gundevia, whose memoirs offer details about the prime minister's routine. Nehru would start his day by meeting the public who had gathered in the lawn of his official residence, Teen Murti House, the former palatial home of the commander-in-chief of the British Indian Army. He would then go to his office in South Block where for the first twenty minutes he would meet with four government secretaries: the Secretary General, foreign secretary, Commonwealth secretary and special secretary. According to Gundevia, 'Each of us carried his own sheaf of pink and yellow telegrams on which we wanted instructions or orders. Jawaharlal had his own collection of telegrams and sometimes one or more letters with him properly sorted out.' Nehru would ask questions and then the officers would be allowed to ask theirs.[16]

Among his political peers, Nehru had to contend mostly with the views of his deputy prime minister and home minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel whom many saw as a potential prime ministerial candidate in his own right. Although Patel was primarily concerned with domestic politics and with integrating the princely states into the Indian Union, he disagreed vehemently with Nehru's foreign policy in relation to China. Cabinet members other than Patel rarely questioned Nehru on foreign policy and a saying of the era was, 'Panditji [Pandit Nehru] knows best.'

Nehru maintained the appearance of formal consultative mechanisms even when he made decisions individually. Other prime ministers have also used cabinet committees to share responsibility for decisions, based on the idea of collective cabinet responsibility in parliamentary governments. The number of cabinet committees has varied over time but the key cabinet committees are: Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs, Cabinet Committee on Security, Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, Cabinet Committee on Parliamentary Affairs, Appointment Committee of the